

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 5

Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	4 — New Beginnings: Cities and States
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. This is the HARDEST paper in the ladder: most stems demand multi-step reasoning, source interpretation, or comparison rather than recall. Hold the classic traps firmly: the First (Harappan, copper and bronze, no coins, undeciphered script) versus the Second (Ganga-plains, iron, silver punch-marked coins) Urbanisation; the roughly thousand-year non-urban gap between them; janapada (small clan territory) versus mahaajanapada (the larger merged state); monarchies with hereditary kings versus the ganas and sanghas (Vajji and Malla) where assemblies decided and chose the ruler; ganas as EARLY republics, not modern democracies with universal suffrage; the Uttaraapatha (north) versus the Dakshinaapatha (south, crossing the Vindhya); and the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas as the southern trio, not northern mahaajanapadas. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A timeline lists five markers but one is misplaced. Reading earliest to latest, which marker sits in the WRONG slot? Slot 1: Harappan urban order. Slot 2: spread of iron in the Ganga plains. Slot 3: the sixteen mahaajanapadas. Slot 4: the long non-urban gap. Slot 5: the first empires.

- (A) Slot 1, the Harappan urban order, which belongs after the spread of iron
- (B) Slot 3, the sixteen mahaajanapadas, which belong before the Harappan order
- (C) Slot 4, the long non-urban gap, which belongs between the Harappan order and the spread of iron, not after the mahaajanapadas
- (D) Slot 5, the first empires, which belong before the mahaajanapadas

2. Two artefacts are dug from the same mound: a copper seal with an undeciphered script and, in a higher layer, a silver coin stamped with several symbols. A careful historian

concludes that:

- (A) Both objects belong to the same Harappan period, since the Harappans used both seals and silver coins
- (B) The lower copper-and-script layer reflects the First Urbanisation and the higher coin layer reflects the much later Second Urbanisation, so a long span separates the two
- (C) The coin is older than the seal because coins were invented before writing
- (D) Both objects belong to the Second Urbanisation, since the Harappans never made seals

3. A debater argues the Ganga-plains wave should be called a 'Harappan revival.' The single piece of evidence that most decisively defeats this label is that:

- (A) The new cities reused the very same Indus citadels and continued the same Harappan script
- (B) The two waves were separated by only a few decades, too short a gap to count as separate
- (C) The Harappans themselves migrated east and rebuilt their old cities under new names
- (D) The new cities arose centuries later in a different region with features the Harappans never had, such as iron and coined money, rather than continuing the Indus cities

4. A historian states: 'The Harappan collapse was a loss of urban ORDER, not merely of buildings.' Which single finding, if genuine, would most strongly UNDERMINE this claim?

- (A) Evidence that trade networks, the writing system and city administration all carried on smoothly with people living urban lives right through the period after the cities fell
- (B) Evidence that after the cities fell people largely returned to village life and large-scale trade and writing faded
- (C) Evidence that roughly a thousand years passed before organised city life reappeared, this time in the Ganga plains
- (D) Evidence that the later Ganga cities used iron and coins the Harappan cities had never possessed

5. Why does the chapter treat the AGREEMENT of archaeology and ancient texts as more trustworthy than either source alone?

- (A) Because ancient texts record the exact spoken words of ordinary people, making the texts alone decisive
- (B) Because an error or bias in one kind of evidence is unlikely to be exactly matched by the other, so a picture both confirm is sturdier
- (C) Because excavation always gives correct dates while texts are always mistaken, so the dig settles everything
- (D) Because the same people who built the first cities also wrote the texts, guaranteeing the two will agree

6. The word janapada joins jana ('people') and pada ('foot'). A student says this naming captures a major historical SHIFT. The reading that best fits both the word and the chapter is that it marks:

- (A) An army permanently on the march, since 'foot' must point to foot-soldiers
- (B) A coin stamped with a footprint and circulated by settled traders
- (C) People who had stopped moving and settled, putting down roots in a territory they identified with
- (D) A vast empire that placed its 'foot' over many distant conquered lands

7. A classmate argues that janapadas should NOT count as early states because they were small and clan-based. Using the chapter's own definition of a state, the best refutation is that:

- (A) He is right, since a true state must rule many distant regions and janapadas were far too small
- (B) He is wrong because janapadas had no leader of any kind and ran purely on custom, which is what defines a state
- (C) He is wrong because janapadas minted their own iron coins from the very beginning, which is what defines a state
- (D) A state needs settled people, a defined territory and an organising authority, and janapadas had all three: clans tied to a land under a rajaa who protected and organised it

8. Why is it a historical error to treat 'janapada' and 'mahaajanapada' as interchangeable words?

- (A) A janapada was a coined unit of money while a mahaajanapada was a long-distance trade route
- (B) A janapada was a smaller, earlier clan territory, while a mahaajanapada was a larger state that formed as such units merged and grew, so the words mark different scales and stages
- (C) A mahaajanapada came first in time and later split into the smaller janapadas
- (D) A janapada was always a republic while a mahaajanapada was always a hereditary monarchy

9. Of the conditions below, which was NOT among the reasons the chapter gives for so many mahaajanapadas clustering in the Ganga plains?

- (A) A cold, dry, riverless plain whose open ground let armies march freely across it
- (B) Fertile alluvial soil that produced food surpluses
- (C) Access to iron for making tools and weapons
- (D) Rivers and trade routes that linked the region together

10. A historian cautions against treating the famous count of 'sixteen mahaajanapadas' as a perfectly fixed official figure. The reasoning that best supports this caution while staying true to the chapter is that:

- (A) The real number was certainly one hundred, and the texts merely rounded it down to sixteen
- (B) The mahaajanapadas never actually existed, so any count of them is pure invention
- (C) Sixteen is the most-cited traditional list, but ancient texts grouped the states in their own ways, so the number reflects textual convention rather than a single exact census
- (D) The list was compiled by the Harappans, whose figures cannot be trusted

11. Which statement best captures what the phrase 'sixteen mahaajanapadas' actually represents?

- (A) Sixteen empires that rose and fell one after another, each replacing the last
- (B) Sixteen small villages clustered together in a single river valley
- (C) A set of large, roughly contemporary states that between them stretched across a wide span of the Subcontinent, from the northwest to the east
- (D) Sixteen different names used for one and the same kingdom

12. A capital combined a rampart, a moat just outside it, and a deliberately narrow gateway. Taken together, these three features most strongly reveal that the rulers were concerned with:

- (A) Defending the city and controlling who and what passed in or out, as a wealthy state with rivals would need to be
- (B) Making the city beautiful for festivals and processions
- (C) Storing rainwater in the moat and gate for use during the dry season
- (D) Encouraging anyone at all to wander in and out as freely as possible

13. In terms of how a fortified state actually worked, why were capital gateways often kept deliberately narrow?

- (A) A narrow gate funnelled traffic to one point so a small guard force could inspect and regulate everyone and everything entering or leaving
- (B) A narrow gate let rainwater drain out of the city much faster
- (C) A narrow gate allowed two war elephants to march through side by side
- (D) A narrow gate made the surrounding wall look more graceful from a distance

14. Rajagriha, Kaushambi and Varanasi were mahaajanapada capitals about 2,500 years ago and remain busy cities today. The soundest inference a historian can draw from this continuity is that:

- (A) Nothing about these places has changed at all in 2,500 years
- (B) They must originally have been founded by the Harappans
- (C) They could never have been fortified, since fortified cities do not last
- (D) Their locations offered lasting natural and strategic advantages that made them worth living on for millennia

15. A museum labels a silver punch-marked coin 'First Urbanisation, Harappan period.' The single reason this label is historically wrong is that:

- (A) The Harappans used only gold coins, never silver ones
- (B) Coined money belongs to the Second Urbanisation, and the Harappans of the First Urbanisation did not use coins at all
- (C) Coins were never used anywhere in ancient India at any time
- (D) Genuine punch-marked coins were made of iron, not silver

16. Why does the spread of punch-marked coins tell historians that TRADE had grown, rather than merely that silver was available?

- (A) Coins are a convenient common medium of exchange, so their spread shows that buying and selling had outgrown what simple barter could handle
- (B) Coins were worn only as jewellery, so their spread shows that personal wealth had grown
- (C) Coins were minted only to be buried with the dead, so they show that funeral customs had grown
- (D) Coins made barter easier to carry out, so their spread shows that barter had become more popular

17. A coin of Avanti is found near Gandhara, and a coin of Anga turns up near the Godavari. The single explanation that accounts for BOTH finds is that:

- (A) Each coin was made on the very spot where it was later found
- (B) All regions of India used one single identical coin, so origin cannot be told
- (C) Coins were forbidden by law to leave the region that minted them
- (D) Coins circulated along the trade routes, so a region's coins could end up far from where they were struck

18. What did the chapter present as the core awkwardness of barter that coins were introduced to solve?

- (A) In barter each side must find a partner who has what they want AND also wants what they have, which is hard to arrange
- (B) Barter could only be carried out after sunset, so daytime trade was impossible
- (C) Barter required a bank in every village before any exchange could take place
- (D) Barter could not work at all without iron tools to complete each swap

19. Usually a mahaajanapada struck its own coins, yet the chapter adds an important qualification. Which statement captures it correctly?

- (A) No region ever accepted another region's coins under any circumstances
- (B) Only the Harappans were permitted to mint coins for everyone else to use
- (C) Coins were banned the moment they crossed outside the capital's walls
- (D) Coins from neighbouring regions were also used and traded, and some even reached beyond India

20. Describing the office of rajaa in a monarchy as 'hereditary' has a clearest practical consequence, which is that:

- (A) The assembly voted to choose a brand-new ruler whenever the throne fell vacant
- (B) The wealthiest merchant in the city automatically became the next ruler
- (C) Power normally passed within the family, typically to the king's son, rather than being awarded afresh each time
- (D) Whichever foreign conqueror arrived next inherited the throne by right

21. Which of the following was NOT among a monarch's main duties as the chapter describes them?

- (A) Keeping law and order across the realm
- (B) Collecting revenue, that is, taxes
- (C) Maintaining an army and the city's fortifications
- (D) Choosing his own successor by holding a public election among the people

22. Within a monarchical mahaajanapada, the relationship between the rajaa and the sabhaa and samiti is best described as:

- (A) The assemblies governed directly and the rajaa was only a powerless figurehead
- (B) The rajaa ignored the assemblies entirely, since they had no role whatsoever
- (C) The assemblies elected a fresh rajaa every single year by open vote
- (D) The rajaa ruled but was expected to take counsel from these assemblies and his ministers rather than act purely on his own whim

23. The names sabhaa and samiti first appear in the Vedas, while gana and sangha describe later political forms. This layering of vocabulary most reasonably suggests to a historian that:

- (A) The Vedas must have been composed after the mahaajanapadas had already ended
- (B) Ideas of collective counsel were old and developed over time into the assemblies and republics of the mahaajanapada age
- (C) Assemblies were a sudden, brand-new invention with no earlier roots at all
- (D) Gana and sangha mean exactly the same thing as a hereditary king

24. In a gana or sangha such as Vajji, how a person became rajaa matters for classifying the state. The correct account is that:

- (A) The assembly selected the ruler through discussion and, if needed, a vote, which is what makes the state a republic rather than a monarchy
- (B) The eldest son of the previous rajaa always inherited the position, exactly as in a monarchy
- (C) Priests carried over from Harappan times appointed the rajaa
- (D) A distant foreign empire imposed the rajaa on the state from outside

25. Vajji and Malla are called 'early republics' yet NOT full modern democracies. The respect in which their assemblies were genuinely broader than a monarchy but still narrower than a modern democracy is that:

- (A) Every adult, including the poorest, voted on fully equal terms exactly as in a modern democracy
- (B) All decisions were taken by the single richest individual in the whole state
- (C) Major decisions were shared among the heads of many leading families rather than resting with one hereditary king, but not every individual had an equal vote
- (D) The decisions were made entirely by foreign rulers from outside the state

26. Comparing a monarchy like Magadha with a gana/sangha like Vajji, the statement that names the KEY governance difference and avoids false contrasts is:

- (A) Magadha practised farming whereas Vajji did not farm at all
- (B) Magadha had no army at all while Vajji maintained a large one
- (C) In Magadha one hereditary rajaa held ultimate power, while in Vajji the assembly took the major decisions and chose the ruler
- (D) Vajji used iron tools while Magadha relied only on bronze

27. The statement 'a good rajaa was not supposed to rule by himself or do whatever he liked' best supports which conclusion about even MONARCHICAL states?

- (A) The rajaa in fact held no real power and the assemblies governed in his place
- (B) Even a king was expected to take counsel from the assemblies and his ministers rather than govern by personal whim
- (C) The people elected a new rajaa every year to keep him in check
- (D) There was no army at all to back up the rajaa's authority

28. Taxation became a regular feature of the mahaajanapadas. The chapter gives as the most important reason a state needed to collect taxes:

- (A) To pay for the armies, fortifications and administration that the ruler maintained
- (B) To replace farming so that no one in the state needed to grow food
- (C) To discourage trade between neighbouring regions
- (D) To abolish the need for any kind of ruler at all

29. The presence of ramparts, regular taxation and standing armies in the mahaajanapadas is taken by the chapter as a sign that they were:

- (A) Loose bands of wanderers with no fixed authority
- (B) Organised states whose rulers could gather and direct resources and defence
- (C) Purely religious settlements with no government of any kind
- (D) Exact reconstructions of the earlier Harappan cities

30. Contrasting the metal expertise of the First Urbanisation with the technological key to the Second, the correct statement is:

- (A) The Harappans used iron, while the second wave returned to bronze
- (B) The Harappans mastered copper and bronze, while the Second Urbanisation was driven by the spread of iron

(C) Both waves depended chiefly on gold tools

(D) The Harappans used iron coins, while the second wave used silver tools

31. A historian says iron was NECESSARY for the Second Urbanisation but not by itself SUFFICIENT. The observation that best illustrates the 'not sufficient' part is that:

(A) Iron alone, with nothing else, instantly produced great cities everywhere it appeared

(B) Iron was never actually used in the Ganga plains at all

(C) Cities had appeared long before iron and so never needed it

(D) Iron also had to combine with fertile soil, trade routes and organised rulers before cities and states could actually grow

32. A farmer in a Ganga-plains janapada switches from a wooden digging stick to an iron-tipped plough. The chain of consequences the chapter would predict is:

(A) Harvests fall, so people abandon the land and the towns shrink

(B) Trade routes close because food no longer needs to be moved

(C) Heavier soil can be worked, harvests rise, the surplus feeds non-farmers, and towns can grow

(D) The need for any ruler or for taxes simply disappears

33. How does the chapter connect stronger, iron-equipped armies to the wider political map of the period?

(A) Stronger armies caused warfare to disappear completely across the plains

(B) Better-armed states could defeat and absorb their neighbours, so kingdoms grew larger, a step toward the first empires

(C) Stronger armies brought farming to an end as soldiers replaced farmers

(D) Stronger armies led directly to the first invention of writing

34. Suppose iron metallurgy had NEVER spread in ancient India. Based on the chapter's reasoning, the most likely outcome would be that:

(A) Cities would have grown even faster than they actually did

(B) The Harappan civilisation would never have ended

(C) Clearing forests and ploughing heavy soil would have been far harder, so the Second Urbanisation would have been much weaker

(D) Coins would have been invented far sooner than they were

35. A student claims, 'The long gap between the two urbanisations proves cities once lost can never return.' The chapter's evidence best refutes this because:

(A) Cities did return, since a wholly new urban wave rose in the Ganga plains after the long non-urban gap

(B) The Harappan cities were in fact never abandoned at all

(C) There was actually no gap at all between the two waves

(D) Cities have existed continuously since the Stone Age, so none were ever lost

36. A jaati is best described as which of the following?

- (A) A deep, water-filled ditch dug to defend a city
- (B) An occupational community whose skills and customs were passed from parents to children
- (C) A long-distance highway used for trade and pilgrimage
- (D) A silver coin stamped with several symbols

37. Within the four-fold varna scheme, which pairing of a varna with its expected role is correct?

- (A) Brahmins were expected to defend the land in battle
- (B) Vaishyas were expected to perform rituals and preserve knowledge
- (C) Kshatriyas were expected to defend society and the land and to wage war when necessary
- (D) Shudras were expected to rule the kingdom as warriors

38. A student says, 'The varna-jaati system was rigid and unchanging from its very first day.' The chapter corrects this by noting that:

- (A) In the early period the system was more flexible, and people could change occupations as circumstances required
- (B) The system never actually existed in this period at all
- (C) The system applied only to the Harappan cities of the First Urbanisation
- (D) The system became completely rigid on the very day it began

39. Two great routes connected India's regions. Which statement matches each route to its direction correctly?

- (A) The Uttaraapatha ran toward the south, while the Dakshinaapatha was the northern route
- (B) Both routes ran only east to west along the coast
- (C) Both routes lay entirely inside a single mahaajanapada
- (D) The Uttaraapatha was the northern route, while the Dakshinaapatha ran toward the south

40. The Dakshinaapatha began near today's Prayagraj, at Kaushambi, and then crossed a particular range to reach the south. That range was the:

- (A) Vindhya Range
- (B) Himalayas
- (C) Aravalli Range
- (D) Western Ghats

41. Beyond goods, what did the two great trade routes also carry that helped knit the Subcontinent together?

- (A) Pilgrims, armies, ideas and coins moving between regions
- (B) Only the rajaa's private letters and nothing else
- (C) Only soldiers, with no other traffic
- (D) Only iron ore, and never any people

42. Around 400 BCE, three kingdoms emerged in the southern part of the Subcontinent. Which set names them?

- (A) Magadha, Kosala and Avanti
- (B) The Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas
- (C) Vajji, Malla and Anga
- (D) Kuru, Panchaala and Matsya

43. Why did the south become drawn into trade with the rest of the Subcontinent?

- (A) It had an unusually cold climate that attracted traders
- (B) It had no rivers at all, which made overland travel simpler
- (C) It held valuable resources such as gems, gold and spices that other regions wanted
- (D) It lay far from the sea, so it needed to import everything by land

44. By about 300-200 BCE, how does the chapter describe the state of the Subcontinent?

- (A) Completely emptied of people once again
- (B) Split into three separate islands
- (C) Ruled once more entirely by the Harappans
- (D) One vibrant, interconnected land whose goods and culture even reached beyond India

45. Around the time India became one interconnected land, what became of the mahaajanapadas?

- (A) They were only just being founded for the very first time
- (B) They came to an end, clearing the way for the first great empires
- (C) They all converted into ganas or sanghas
- (D) They relocated westward into the Indus valley

46. Magadha, in today's Bihar, became one of the most powerful mahaajanapadas.

Following the chapter's logic, the single best reason is that it:

- (A) Had no rivers, which made it naturally easy to defend
- (B) Sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain with food surpluses, river transport and nearby resources
- (C) Was a gana or sangha that elected its own rulers
- (D) Lay far to the south near the Pandyas

47. Shishupalgarh, an eastern city with a neat square plan and strong fortifications, was the capital associated with which region?

- (A) Magadha
- (B) Gandhaara
- (C) Kalinga
- (D) Avanti

48. Why does the chapter present the rise of cities, the growth of states and the appearance of coins as ONE connected story rather than three unrelated events?

- (A) They happened in three different millennia with no link between them
- (B) Surplus farming fed cities and states, the growing trade required coins, and each development reinforced the others

- (C) Coins appeared first and only later caused any farming to begin
- (D) Each of the three unfolded on a separate continent

49. If a region had fertile soil and iron but lay completely off all the trade routes, the chapter's reasoning suggests its prospects as a great state would be:

- (A) Weaker, because without trade links it would miss the exchange of goods, coins and ideas that helped states flourish
- (B) Stronger, because isolation always protects a state from harm
- (C) Unchanged, because trade played no role at all in the growth of states
- (D) Guaranteed to become the largest empire of the age

50. A teacher writes the timeline note 'janapadas merge into mahaajanapadas.' Reasoning about WHY this merging happened, which explanation fits the chapter best?

- (A) The Harappans returned and combined the janapadas for them
- (B) All janapadas peacefully dissolved because no one wanted land any more
- (C) Foreign empires arrived first and split big states into janapadas
- (D) Stronger janapadas absorbed weaker neighbours through war and alliance, helped by iron weapons and growing wealth, forming larger states

51. A historian wishes to demonstrate that the mahaajanapadas were organised STATES rather than mere settlements. Which single combination of evidence would best serve that argument?

- (A) Fortified capitals, the regular collection of taxes, and the maintenance of standing armies
- (B) Undeciphered Harappan seals, standardised weights, and planned drainage
- (C) The complete absence of any rulers, assemblies or coins
- (D) Cowrie-shell exchange, with no walls, no taxes and no army

52. A coin found far from its mint and a 2,500-year-old capital still inhabited today are cited as evidence for two different chapter claims. Which pairing correctly matches each find to the claim it supports?

- (A) The travelled coin supports the continuity of the Second Urbanisation; the still-living capital supports long-distance trade
- (B) Both finds together prove that the Harappans founded the Ganga-plains cities
- (C) The travelled coin supports long-distance trade along the routes; the still-living capital supports the continuity of the Second Urbanisation
- (D) Both finds together prove that barter never gave way to coined money

53. A student says, 'Because the gana/sangha assemblies chose their rulers, they were exactly the same as a modern democracy.' The most accurate correction is that:

- (A) Correct, since every adult in a gana or sangha voted equally just as in a modern democracy
- (B) Wrong, because the gana/sangha rulers actually inherited power by birth like kings

- (C) Wrong, because the gana/sangha assemblies in fact took no decisions at all
- (D) They were broader than a monarchy since many family heads decided together, but narrower than a modern democracy because not every individual had an equal vote

54. A label reads, 'In the mahaajanapada age, the monarch ruled entirely alone and answered to no one.' The chapter contradicts this because:

- (A) Monarchies did not exist in the mahaajanapada age at all
- (B) The assemblies, not the king, governed every monarchy directly
- (C) The people elected and removed the monarch each and every year
- (D) Even a hereditary king was expected to take counsel from assemblies such as the sabhaa and samiti and from his ministers rather than rule by his own whim

55. A student arranges the deeper causes behind the Second Urbanisation as a chain, with the most basic enabling condition first. Which ordering best matches the chapter's reasoning?

- (A) Growing trade needing coins, then spread of iron, then larger cities, then more land cleared, then larger food surpluses
- (B) Larger cities and states, then larger food surpluses, then spread of iron, then more land cleared, then growing trade
- (C) Larger food surpluses, then spread of iron, then growing trade, then more land cleared, then larger cities
- (D) Spread of iron, then more land cleared and heavier soil ploughed, then larger food surpluses, then growing trade needing coins, then larger cities and states

56. Why is the spread of iron treated as part of what DISTINGUISHES the Second Urbanisation from the First, rather than as a shared feature of both?

- (A) Iron was used heavily by the Harappans but abandoned in the second wave, which returned to bronze
- (B) Both waves relied on iron equally, so it cannot distinguish them at all
- (C) Iron came into general use only in the later Ganga-plains phase, whereas the Harappans of the First Urbanisation worked copper and bronze, not iron
- (D) Iron was used only for minting coins in both periods, so it tells the two waves apart by their money

57. A scholar compares the FIRST Urbanisation's script with the SECOND's record of trade. The sharpest contrast the chapter would draw is that:

- (A) Both periods left fully readable scripts that historians decode with equal ease
- (B) The Harappan script remains undeciphered, whereas the Second Urbanisation left both excavated remains and readable ancient texts that historians can use together
- (C) The Harappan script is fully understood, while the Second Urbanisation left nothing in writing
- (D) Neither period left any written or material evidence, so both rest only on guesswork

58. A region has fertile soil, plentiful iron, and sits on a major trade route, yet its assembly of leading families, not a single hereditary king, takes the major decisions. From the chapter's categories, this region is best classified as a:

- (A) Hereditary monarchy like Magadha
- (B) Janapada that has not yet merged into any larger state
- (C) Harappan First-Urbanisation city
- (D) Gana or sangha, that is, an early republic among the mahaajanapadas

59. The mahaajanapadas stretched from Gandhara in the northwest to Anga in the east, with Ashmaka set near a southern river. The chapter's point in tracing this wide span is best summed up as:

- (A) All sixteen were squeezed into one small stretch of the Indus valley
- (B) Only the Ganga plains held any mahaajanapadas, with none anywhere else
- (C) These large states between them covered much of the Subcontinent, far beyond a single river valley
- (D) The span shows the mahaajanapadas were all ruled by one single emperor

60. A reader concludes from the chapter that the Second Urbanisation 'has never really stopped, but continues to this day.' The fact that best backs this up is that:

- (A) Several mahaajanapada capitals, such as Varanasi, are still living, busy cities about 2,500 years later
- (B) All the Harappan cities of the First Urbanisation are still inhabited today
- (C) Iron tools have completely fallen out of use in modern times
- (D) Barter is still the main form of trade across India today

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States — Paper 5

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	C	11	C	21	D	31	D	41	A	51	A
2	B	12	A	22	D	32	C	42	B	52	C
3	D	13	A	23	B	33	B	43	C	53	D
4	A	14	D	24	A	34	C	44	D	54	D
5	B	15	B	25	C	35	A	45	B	55	D
6	C	16	A	26	C	36	B	46	B	56	C
7	D	17	D	27	B	37	C	47	C	57	B
8	B	18	A	28	A	38	A	48	B	58	D
9	A	19	D	29	B	39	D	49	A	59	C
10	C	20	C	30	B	40	A	50	D	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (C) The correct order is Harappan order, then the long non-urban gap of roughly a thousand years, then the spread of iron, then the mahaajanapadas, then the first empires; so the gap is wrongly placed at the very end. The Harappan order is genuinely first, not after iron. The mahaajanapadas come late, well after the Harappans, not before them. The first empires are the final stage, growing out of the mahaajanapadas, so they cannot precede them.

2. (B) Copper seals with undeciphered script are hallmarks of the Harappan First Urbanisation, while silver punch-marked coins belong to the later Second Urbanisation, and the higher layer being later fits that long separation. The Harappans did not use coins of any metal, so the first distractor is false. In an undisturbed mound a higher layer is younger, so the coin is not older than the seal. Seals are precisely a Harappan feature, so claiming the Harappans never made seals is wrong.

3. (D) A revival would require the same people, place and features carrying on, but the Ganga wave was a fresh rise in a new region with iron and coins the Harappans lacked, which settles it as a Second Urbanisation. It did not reuse the Indus citadels or continue the undeciphered script. The gap was about a thousand non-urban years, not a few decades. The chapter describes no Harappan migration east rebuilding the old cities.

4. (A) The claim is that a whole working system, not just walls, was lost; only the survival of trade, writing and administration with continued urban life would undermine it. People returning to village life with trade and writing fading actually supports the claim of lost order. A thousand-year gap before cities returned also supports it. The later cities' iron and coins concern the second wave's novelty and say nothing against the earlier loss.

5. (B) Two independent lines converging is convincing precisely because they are unlikely to share the same mistake. Texts do not preserve ordinary people's exact spoken words, and dismissing archaeology overstates the texts. Treating texts as always wrong discards a whole source unfairly. The Harappan First-Urbanisation people did not write the later, differently-scripted texts, so that guarantee is impossible.

6. (C) Where 'the people set foot' signals a community that settled and tied itself to a fixed land, exactly the shift that made early states possible. An army on the march contradicts settling down. A footprint coin confuses a territory with money. An empire overshoots the scale of a single clan's home territory.

7. (D) The chapter's marks of a state are settled population, fixed territory and an organising authority, and janapadas met all three under a rajaa, so size does not disqualify them. Requiring rule over many regions imposes an empire-sized test the chapter never sets. Having no leader is false, since a rajaa led the janapada. Iron coins from the start is an anachronism, as coined silver money belongs to a later stage.

8. (B) The prefix maha- means great, marking scale: mahaajanapadas were the larger states into which earlier janapadas merged. Neither word names a coin or a route. The direction of change ran from small to large, not large to small. Both monarchies and ganas/sanghas existed among the mahaajanapadas, so the republic-versus-monarchy contrast is false.

9. (A) The chapter credits fertile soil, available iron and connecting rivers and routes; a cold, dry, riverless plain is the opposite, since rivers were a key advantage, so that is the odd one out. Fertile soil with surpluses is a genuine reason. Access to iron is a genuine reason. Rivers and routes linking the region is a genuine reason.

10. (C) Sixteen is a useful traditional grouping from the textual tradition, not a precise modern headcount, so a little caution is fair. Asserting it was certainly one hundred invents a precise figure the chapter never gives. Denying the mahaajanapadas existed

contradicts well-attested states. The Harappans vanished long before these lists, so they could not have compiled them.

11. (C) The sixteen were many distinct, sizeable states existing around the same time and spread over a broad region from Gandhara to Anga. Calling them successive empires turns contemporaries into a sequence. Calling them villages in one valley shrinks states into a hamlet cluster. Calling them names for one kingdom collapses many states into one, which the wide span contradicts.

12. (A) Walls, a water-filled ditch and a pinch-point gate form one coherent defence-and-control package, exactly what a rich state with rivals would build. Beauty for festivals ignores that all three are defensive. Storing rainwater is contradicted by the rampart and narrow gate, which are not water tanks. Free wandering is directly contradicted by the narrow gate, whose point is to restrict movement.

13. (A) Narrowing the gate concentrates movement at one controllable point, letting few guards watch, inspect and even collect tolls. Draining rainwater confuses a gateway with a drain. Two elephants side by side would need a wide gate, the opposite of narrow. Looking graceful treats a security feature as mere decoration.

14. (D) Continuous occupation for 2,500 years points to enduring site advantages such as fertile surroundings, river access and trade position. Continuity is not the same as being frozen, so 'nothing changed' is wrong. These were Second-Urbanisation capitals, not Harappan foundations. The chapter describes them as ramparted and moated, so 'never fortified' is false.

15. (B) Punch-marked coins appeared in the later Ganga-plains wave; the Harappans had no coinage of any kind, so dating a coin to their period is the error. They used no gold coins either. Coins were used in ancient India, just later, so 'never anywhere' is false. Punch-marked coins were silver, not iron, so naming the metal iron is wrong.

16. (A) A medium of exchange exists to ease buying and selling, so its widespread use signals expanding commerce beyond barter's reach. Treating coins as jewellery ignores their role as money. Treating them as grave goods reduces a trade tool to a burial item. Saying coins made barter more popular is self-contradictory, since coins mark a move away from barter.

17. (D) Coins drifting far from home is the natural signature of long-distance trade carrying them along the routes, and one cause explains both finds. 'Made on the spot' contradicts the coins being identified with distant regions. 'One identical coin' is false, since regions usually struck their own, which is how these can be traced to Avanti and Anga. 'Forbidden to leave' would make such finds impossible.

18. (A) The double difficulty of matching wants is what makes barter clumsy, and a common coin removes it. A sunset restriction is invented. A bank in every village is

anachronistic, since barter predates banks. Needing iron tools falsely links swapping goods to a particular technology.

19. (D) Although each region usually made its own coins, neighbouring coins also circulated along trade routes, even abroad. 'Never accepted another region's coins' contradicts the finds of foreign coins. 'Only the Harappans minted' is impossible, since coins postdate the Harappans entirely. 'Banned outside the capital' contradicts the cross-regional circulation described.

20. (C) Hereditary means power is inherited by birth, so the throne usually went to the king's son or kin, the trait that separates a monarchy from a gana/sangha. The assembly voting each time describes a republic. The wealthiest merchant ignores birth as the basis of succession. A foreign conqueror confuses conquest with inheritance.

21. (D) A monarch's duties included keeping order, collecting revenue and maintaining defence; succession was hereditary, not decided by public election, so the election option is the duty that does not belong. Keeping law and order is genuine. Collecting taxes is genuine. Maintaining an army and fortifications is genuine.

22. (D) In a monarchy the king held power yet was supposed to govern with the advice of the sabha and samiti and his ministers, sharing counsel but not rule. 'Assemblies governed directly, king a figurehead' describes a republic. 'Ignored entirely' erases the advisory role the chapter affirms. 'Fresh king every year by vote' contradicts hereditary kingship.

23. (B) Older Vedic words for assemblies alongside later republican terms point to a continuous, evolving tradition of shared decision-making. 'Vedas composed after the mahaajanapadas' reverses the time order the layering implies. 'No earlier roots' ignores that the Vedic terms show exactly such roots. 'Gana and sangha mean a hereditary king' is backwards, since those terms describe republics.

24. (A) In a gana/sangha the assembly chose the ruler by debate and, if necessary, a vote, and that locus of decision is the defining republican trait. Inheritance by the eldest son describes a monarchy. Harappan priests appointing the ruler is impossible, since the Harappans were long gone. A foreign empire imposing the ruler misdescribes how these early republics chose their leaders.

25. (C) These republics spread decision-making across many family and clan heads, broader than one king's will yet short of universal suffrage. 'Every adult voted equally' overstates inclusion into a modern democracy. 'Single richest individual' narrows power to one person, contradicting shared decision-making. 'Foreign rulers decided' removes self-rule, the opposite of a republic.

26. (C) The essential contrast is WHO decides: a single inheriting king versus a decision-making assembly that also picks the ruler. Both relied on farming, so the farming contrast

is false. Both maintained armies, so the army contrast is false. Both belonged to the iron age, so the iron-versus-bronze contrast is false.

27. (B) The line shows the king governed WITH advice, not that he was powerless or yearly-replaced. 'No real power, assemblies governed' overshoots into a republic. 'Elected every year' contradicts hereditary kingship. 'No army at all' is unrelated and contradicts the monarch's duty of maintaining an army.

28. (A) Taxes funded the costly running of a state: soldiers, walls and officials. 'Replace farming' is false, since taxes were often levied on farm produce rather than replacing it. 'Discourage trade' is false, since states benefited from trade. 'Abolish the need for a ruler' is self-contradictory, since collecting revenue is itself one of the ruler's functions.

29. (B) Walls, tax collection and armies require an authority able to mobilise resources, the hallmark of organised states. Wandering bands contradict the fixed, organised authority such features imply. Purely religious settlements ignore the very governing apparatus described. Reconstructions of Harappan cities is false, since these were new Ganga-age states, not copies of the long-collapsed order.

30. (B) The First Urbanisation worked copper and bronze; iron became widespread only in the later Ganga-plains wave, which it powered. 'Harappans used iron, second wave bronze' reverses the two. 'Both depended on gold tools' is false for both waves. 'Harappan iron coins' is doubly wrong, since the Harappans had no coins and did not work iron.

31. (D) 'Necessary but not sufficient' means iron was required yet had to act together with soil, routes and rulers to yield cities. 'Iron alone instantly produced cities' claims sufficiency, the opposite point. 'Never used in the Ganga plains' denies iron's necessity. 'Cities appeared before iron' contradicts the chapter's sequence, in which iron came first and enabled the growth.

32. (C) An iron plough breaks tougher soil and grows more, generating the surplus that supports town-dwellers, the engine of urban growth. 'Harvests fall' reverses the expected effect. 'Trade routes close' is wrong, since more surplus means more trade. 'Need for rulers and taxes disappears' is wrong, since a larger settled population needs more administration, not less.

33. (B) Iron weapons made armies more effective, helping powerful states conquer and merge rivals into larger kingdoms. Warfare disappearing is the opposite of what stronger armies imply. Farming ending is false, since farming expanded with iron ploughs. Leading to writing links two unrelated developments.

34. (C) Since iron tools enabled the land-clearing and farming behind the surplus, removing iron would have starved that surplus and weakened the urban wave. 'Cities grew even faster' contradicts iron's enabling role. 'Harappan civilisation never ended' is irrelevant, since its collapse happened long before and for other reasons. 'Coins invented

sooner' is unsupported, since the money economy rested on the trade that iron-fed growth made possible.

35. (A) The Second Urbanisation itself disproves the claim, since after about a thousand non-urban years city life reappeared in a new region. 'Never abandoned' is false, since the Harappan cities were indeed lost. 'No gap at all' denies the well-attested gap. 'Cities since the Stone Age' overstates continuity and ignores the documented break.

36. (B) A jaati was a community defined by occupation, with skills and customs handed down within families. A water-filled ditch describes a moat. A long-distance highway describes a patha or trade route. A silver coin describes a punch-marked coin, not a social group.

37. (C) Kshatriyas were the varna associated with protection and warfare. Brahmins were linked with knowledge and rituals, not battle. Vaishyas were linked with trade and agriculture, not rituals. Shudras were linked with service occupations, not ruling as warriors.

38. (A) The chapter stresses that in this early phase movement between occupations was possible, so it was not fixed from the start. 'Never existed' denies a system the chapter describes. 'Only the Harappan cities' is wrong, since it belongs to the later Ganga-plains age. 'Rigid on the very day it began' restates the misconception rather than correcting it.

39. (D) 'Uttara' means north and 'dakshina' means south, so the names fix the directions: Uttaraapatha north, Dakshinaapatha south. The first distractor reverses them. 'East to west along the coast' misdescribes routes that ran broadly north and south. 'Inside a single mahaajanapada' shrinks routes that spanned many regions into one state.

40. (A) To pass from the northern plains into the peninsula, the southern route crossed the Vindhyas, the dividing range between north and south India. The Himalayas lie far to the north, the wrong direction. The Aravallis run through the northwest, off the southward path. The Western Ghats edge the western coast and are not the range a route from Kaushambi southward would first cross.

41. (A) The routes were arteries for people and ideas as well as merchandise: pilgrims, armies, beliefs and coins all travelled along them. 'Only royal letters' is far too narrow. 'Only soldiers' ignores pilgrims, ideas and coins. 'Only iron ore, never people' contradicts the mixing of people and ideas that helped unify the regions.

42. (B) The southern trio were the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas. Magadha, Kosala and Avanti were powerful northern mahaajanapadas. Vajji, Malla and Anga lay in the north and east. Kuru, Panchaala and Matsya were northern janapadas/mahaajanapadas, so only the Chola-Chera-Pandya set is southern.

43. (C) The south's prized resources, gems, gold and spices, pulled it into the wider trade networks. A cold climate is neither accurate nor a draw for trade. 'No rivers, easier travel' is wrong, since the absence of rivers would hinder movement. 'Far from the sea' is false, since the south's coastal position actually aided maritime trade.

44. (D) By this date trade, coins and ideas had linked the regions into a single connected land, with influence spilling beyond India's borders. 'Emptied of people' contradicts the bustling, connected picture. 'Three separate islands' is geographically false. 'Ruled by the Harappans again' is impossible, since the Harappan civilisation had ended roughly a thousand years earlier.

45. (B) As the land integrated, the mahaajanapadas gave way to the early empires, the next, larger stage of state formation. 'Just being founded' puts their beginning where their end belongs. 'All became republics' is false, since their era was ending, not transforming wholesale. 'Relocated into the Indus valley' invents a migration the chapter does not describe.

46. (B) Magadha's strength flowed from its fertile Ganga location, rich harvests, river routes and access to resources such as iron, the very ingredients the chapter ties to powerful states. 'No rivers' is wrong, since rivers were an asset, not a defensive gap. 'Gana/sangha that elected rulers' misclassifies Magadha, a monarchy. 'Far to the south near the Pandyas' misplaces a northern state.

47. (C) Shishupalgarh, in the east with its square fortified plan, was the capital associated with Kalinga. Magadha, in Bihar, had capitals such as Rajagriha, not an eastern square-planned site. Gandhara lay in the far northwest. Avanti lay in central-western India, none of which matches an eastern, square-planned city.

48. (B) The developments are interlinked: agricultural surplus underpinned cities and states, the resulting trade called for coins, and each fed back into the others. 'Three different millennia' separates roughly contemporary events. 'Coins first, then farming' reverses the order, since surplus farming preceded and enabled coins. 'Separate continent' is plainly false, since all unfolded in the same land.

49. (A) Fertile soil and iron give surplus, but the chapter ties powerful states to connectivity as well; cut off from routes, a region would lose the exchange of goods, coins and ideas. 'Isolation always protects' treats being cut off as an advantage the chapter does not grant. 'Trade played no role' contradicts the chapter's emphasis on connectivity. 'Guaranteed largest empire' overclaims from soil and iron alone.

50. (D) Larger states formed as more powerful janapadas, backed by iron arms and surplus wealth, defeated or absorbed weaker ones. 'Harappans returned' is impossible, since they had long since vanished. 'No one wanted land any more' contradicts clans'

strong ties to their territory. 'Foreign empires split states into janapadas' reverses the direction, which ran from small units to large.

51. (A) Walls, taxation and armies together require an authority able to gather and direct resources, which is exactly what marks an organised state. Harappan seals, weights and drainage point to the earlier First Urbanisation, not these states. The absence of rulers, assemblies or coins would argue against statehood, not for it. Cowrie exchange with no walls, taxes or army lacks every feature that signals an organised state.

52. (C) A coin drifting far from its mint is the signature of trade carrying it along routes, while a capital alive after 2,500 years shows the second wave's unbroken continuity, so each find supports its own claim. The first distractor swaps the two matches. 'Harappans founded the Ganga cities' is false, since those cities were not Harappan. 'Barter never gave way to coins' contradicts the rise of coined money the travelled coin reflects.

53. (D) These early republics shared decisions among many leading-family heads, broader than one king's will yet short of universal suffrage, so 'early' not 'modern' is right. 'Every adult voted equally' overstates inclusion. 'Rulers inherited by birth' is false, since the assembly chose them, which is what makes them republics. 'Assemblies took no decisions' contradicts their defining feature.

54. (D) The chapter stresses that a good rajaa governed with the counsel of the assemblies and ministers, not by himself, so 'ruled entirely alone' is wrong. 'Monarchies did not exist' is false, since most mahaajanapadas were monarchies. 'Assemblies governed directly' describes a republic, not a monarchy. 'Elected and removed each year' contradicts hereditary kingship.

55. (D) The chapter's logic begins with iron, which let people clear land and work heavy soil, producing surpluses that fed cities and supported trade needing coins, so cities and states grew. The first distractor puts trade and coins before the iron that made them possible. The second puts cities before the iron and surplus that built them. The third places surplus before the iron that produced it, breaking the causal order.

56. (C) Iron became widespread only in the second wave; the Harappans worked copper and bronze, so iron marks the later phase, not a shared feature. 'Harappans used iron, abandoned later' reverses the truth. 'Both relied on iron equally' is false, since the First Urbanisation did not use iron. 'Iron only for coins' is wrong, since coins were silver, not iron, and were a Second-Urbanisation development.

57. (B) The Harappan script stays undeciphered, while the Second Urbanisation is reconstructed from both archaeology and readable ancient texts, the pairing the chapter prizes. 'Both fully readable with equal ease' is false, since the Harappan script is not read. 'Harappan script fully understood, second wave wrote nothing' reverses both facts.

'Neither left any evidence' contradicts the seals, ruins, texts and coins the chapter discusses.

58. (D) Decision-making resting with an assembly of leading families rather than one hereditary king is the defining mark of a gana or sangha, the early-republic type such as Vajji or Malla. A hereditary monarchy like Magadha is ruled by an inheriting king, not an assembly. A janapada is a smaller, earlier clan territory, but the iron, routes and assembly here describe a developed mahaajanapada. A Harappan city predates iron and coins entirely, so it cannot fit a route-linked, iron-using state.

59. (C) Naming states from the far northwest to the east underlines that the mahaajanapadas spread across much of the Subcontinent, not one valley. 'Squeezed into the Indus valley' contradicts the Gandhaara-to-Anga reach. 'Only the Ganga plains' is wrong, since Gandhaara, Anga and Ashmaka lie outside it. 'One single emperor' is false, since these were many separate states, not one empire, which only came later.

60. (A) The clearest support is that Second-Urbanisation cities like Varanasi remain alive and busy after roughly 2,500 years, an unbroken thread. 'Harappan cities still inhabited' is false and concerns the First Urbanisation. 'Iron fallen out of use' is false. 'Barter still the main trade' is false, so none of these supports the claim.